

Build Steps

Cowork is task-driven — give Copilot a job, optionally schedule it, let it use your M365.

1 Open Copilot Cowork

Open Microsoft 365 Copilot and switch to Cowork mode (left rail). Confirm the surfaces you have available — Cowork can act on your behalf across:

- Outlook (read, summarise, draft, send, schedule)
- Teams (chats, channels, post messages, read history)
- Calendar (find times, create meetings, prep briefs)
- SharePoint & OneDrive (read files, write Word/Excel/PowerPoint to your files)
- Power BI (semantic models, reports, DAX queries)

2 Paste the Headline Task

Open a new Cowork task and paste the prompt below. This is the worked example for Finance — Variance & Control Sweep — adapt names, channels, and Power BI reports to your tenant before running.

On the 1st working day of each month at 8:00am, run the Variance & Control Sweep:

1. Do NOT send/post automatically — leave the draft for me to review.
2. Open Finance_Audit_Data.xlsx from /Finance/Audit/ in SharePoint. Read every journal row for the prior Period.
3. For each row, capture: JournalID, CostCentre, Account, Description, NetUSD, ControlFlag, VarianceVsBudgetPct, Approver, PostedDate.
4. Build the Failed-Controls list: every row where ControlFlag = Fail. Sort by absolute NetUSD descending.
5. Build the Review-Needed list: every row where ControlFlag = Review OR |VarianceVsBudgetPct| > 10%.
6. For each CostCentre on either list, search my mailbox for the last 30 days for messages from the Approver mentioning the CostCentre or Account. Pull any one-line context they already gave (eg 'one-off reclass', 'timing of accrual').
7. Build an Excel workbook saved to /Finance/Month End/ Variance_<period>.xlsx with three tabs: Failed-Controls, Review-Needed, Summary (counts and total absolute NetUSD per CostCentre). Cite the source JournalID in every row.
8. Draft an email to the Internal Audit DL: counts by control status, top 5 by NetUSD, link to the workbook, and a list of CostCentre owners who already provided context vs those still owed an ask. Leave as draft.
9. For each Approver tied to a Failed control with no prior context, draft a short email asking them to confirm the driver and submit a variance note by EOW. Cite JournalID and NetUSD. Leave drafts.
10. Never invent numbers. Every figure must trace to a JournalID — if you can't cite it, don't claim it.

3 Set the Schedule

In the task panel, choose Schedule and configure:

Frequency	Monthly
Run Time	1st working day, 08:00 (before close stand-up)
Execution Mode	Inline (recommended) — task remembers context across runs

4 Verify the First Run

Run once now (Run now) before scheduling kicks in. Confirm:

- Failed-Controls count matches a manual filter on ControlFlag=Fail
- Variance % threshold fires correctly — try a row at 9.9% vs 10.1%
- Every row in the workbook has a JournalID citation

No invented totals — spot check the Summary tab against the source

Try These Live

Copy any of these into a new Cowork task — one-shot or scheduled.

Approver Concentration Risk

From the workbook, count approvals per Approver across the last 90 days. Flag any Approver who signed off on more than 25% of all journals OR more than 50% of Fail/Review rows in any single CostCentre. Build a Word memo to the Controller with the table and a 'segregation of duties' note. Leave as draft.

Late-Posting Sweep

List journals where PostedDate is more than 5 working days after Period end. Group by CostCentre and Approver. Draft a Teams message to the FP&A channel with the table and a reminder of the close calendar. Leave as draft.

Top-Variance Drill

Take the top 10 rows by |VarianceVsBudgetPct|. For each, search my mailbox for the CostCentre owner's most recent explanation. Build a one-page Word brief: row, variance, owner's stated driver (quoted), evidence link. Email it to the FP&A lead. Leave as draft.

Audit-Trail Quick Look

I'll paste a JournalID. Pull the row from the workbook, any related rows (same CostCentre + Account within 7 days), and any mailbox thread referencing that JournalID or the same Description. Build a one-page audit-trail Word doc.

How to Think About This Teammate

Cowork replaces:

- Hand-building the monthly variance pack
- Chasing approvers for variance commentary by email
- Audit prep as a quarterly fire drill

With:

- ✓ A controls workbook ready on day 1 of month-end
- ✓ Approver outreach with JournalID and NetUSD in
- ✓ Audit trail one paste-and-go task away

Not a chatbot. A scheduled teammate with full access to your M365.

Tip for real-world use

Finance's non-negotiable: cite the source. Pin into every prompt: 'Every number must trace to a JournalID. If you can't cite it, don't claim it.' Pair with draft-only outbound — the audit trail builds itself.

You've built a Cowork teammate ✓

You now have a Copilot teammate that can:

- Run the variance sweep on day 1, not day 5
- Trace every claim to a JournalID
- Surface control failures with context attached
- Cut close cycle days, not finance heads